

Cuban Bread

Same-day · lard-structural · soft pale crust · built for the Cubano press

YIELD	FLOUR	HYDRATION	BAKE	TOTAL TIME
8 @ ~160g	AP ~11%	63%	400°F	~4–4.5 hr

DOUGH

AP flour, NOT bread flour — tenderness over chew

INGREDIENT	BAKER %	WEIGHT
AP flour (~10.5–11.5% protein)	100%	750 g
Water (warm; ~100g reserved to bloom yeast)	63%	475 g
Lard (your rendered pork lard — structural)	4%	30 g
Sugar (feeds the bloom)	2%	15 g
Salt	2%	15 g
ADY (bloomed — see step 1)	1.5%	11 g

Total ~1,294g dough → eight ~160g loaves. KitchenAid handles this in one batch — a docile dough, opposite of high-gluten loads.

METHOD

Same-day, single rise, ~4–4.5 hr at 70°F

- 1

Bloom the ADY: dissolve yeast + sugar in ~100g of the water at **100–110°F**. Wait **5–10 min** for foam — that's proof of life. Too cold = sluggish, over ~115°F = dead.
- 2

Mix: combine flour, salt, lard, the bloom, and remaining water. Knead to **moderate** gluten — smooth and soft, NOT full windowpane. ~8–10 min.
- 3

Bulk rise: ~**1.5–2 hr** until doubled at **70°F**. Go by the dough (doubled), not the clock — at room temp 1.5% ADY isn't as fast as a warm proofbox. (model-reasoned; first bake locks the real time)
- 4

Divide & shape: 8 × 160g. Short **~8" torpedoes with blunt rounded ends** (not tapered points). Seam-side down.
- 5

Proof: 45–60 min until puffy and light.
- 6

Score: one straight lengthwise slash per loaf.
- 7

Bake 400°F with steam (pan of water / ice cubes) first 10 min, then dry. ~20–22 min to **pale golden**, internal **200–205°F**. Do NOT bake dark.
- 8

Finish soft: brush hot loaves with melted lard or butter. Keeps the crust soft and pressable.

Lard does double duty: in the dough it shortens gluten for the soft, cottony crumb; brushed on hot it keeps the crust soft. Same lard as the pork roast — one ingredient ties the whole Cubano system together.

Principles & Reads

KEY PRINCIPLES

Cuban bread breaks the high-gluten instinct

AP flour, go DOWN in protein	Opposite of pizza/bagels. ~11% AP gives a tender, soft crumb that compresses cleanly in the press. High-gluten flour bakes tough and eats rubbery here.
Lard is structural	~4% shortens gluten strands — the soft, almost cottony crumb and tender bite. Without it you've made a French loaf, not Cuban bread.
Pale, thin crust by design	400°F and pull at pale golden. Hard browning makes a thick chewy crust — the wrong vehicle for a press. Fights your char instinct; that's correct.
Same-day, lean & fast	No cold ferment, no poolish. Flavor comes from lard + bake, not long fermentation. High yeast, one bulk, done in hours.
Moderate gluten only	Knead to smooth/soft, not windowpane. Over-developed gluten makes it chewy and press-resistant.

DIAGNOSTICS

Tough / chewy, fights the press	Flour too strong or over-kneaded. Use AP, stop at moderate gluten.
Thick, hard crust	Baked too long / too hot / too dark. Pull paler, hold 400°F, brush with fat out of the oven.
Dense, didn't rise	Dead/sluggish ADY. Bloom water was too hot or too cold — confirm foam before mixing.
Crumb too open / holey	Over-proofed or hydration creeping high. Tighten the shape, watch the proof.
Crust crisp then leathery	Skipped the post-bake fat brush. Brush hot for a soft, pressable crust.

Built for the press: every choice here — AP flour, lard, pale thin crust, soft finish — optimizes this loaf as the vehicle for the pressed Cubano, not as a standalone artisan loaf. Pair with Cuban Pork & Mojo v2.0.